

CanTee

A T-shirt sealed in a can — with seeds inside so the packaging becomes a plant pot.

What It Is

An apparel brand that sells T-shirts vacuum-sealed inside reusable metal cans instead of plastic bags. Each can includes a packet of flower seeds, so after the customer opens it and takes out the shirt, the can becomes a planter. The packaging is the product and the marketing — people film the unboxing and share it, giving the brand reach that plain poly-bags never could.

How It Makes Money

Direct-to-consumer apparel sales at a premium price justified by the novelty packaging and sustainability story. Revenue from individual canned shirts, multi-can gift sets, limited drops, and wholesale to boutiques and eco-gift shops. The unboxing content lowers your ad costs over time.

Startup Costs

- Blank T-shirts (Alibaba/Bella+Canvas/Gildan: "blank cotton t-shirt bulk"): \$2.50–\$5.00 each
- Printing (screen print or DTG): \$2–\$5 per shirt
- Custom metal cans with full-wrap label (Alibaba: "custom printed tin can packaging" / "t-shirt can packaging"): \$0.80–\$1.80 each, MOQ 500–1,000
- Seed packets: \$0.10–\$0.25 each (bulk wildflower seed)
- Can-sealing machine: \$150–\$500
- Branding, Shopify store, photography: \$600–\$1,500
- First-month ads/influencer seeding: \$800–\$2,000
- **Total to launch: \$3,500–\$8,000**

The Numbers

- Cost per canned shirt: shirt \$4 + print \$3 + can/label \$1.40 + seeds \$0.20 = **~\$8.60**
- Sell price: \$32–\$45
- Profit per unit: \$23–\$36
- Wholesale price: \$18–\$22 (still ~\$10 profit)
- Sell 500–900 cans/month across DTC + wholesale = **\$16,000–\$36,000 revenue, \$11,000–\$26,000 profit/month**, with drop launches spiking volume.

How To Start

1. Pick a tight niche (eco/streetwear/local-pride) and design 3–5 shirts with strong, simple graphics.
2. Source blanks and a custom can supplier on Alibaba; order samples to confirm the shirt fits and the can seals cleanly.
3. Buy a sealing machine and test the full unbox: peel, pull shirt, reveal seeds, plant.
4. Place a first run of 500–1,000 cans across your best designs.
5. Shoot a crisp unboxing reel — the can pop and seed reveal is the hook.

6. Launch as a limited drop on Shopify to create urgency and shares.
7. Add a wholesale line and pitch eco-boutiques and gift shops via Faire.

Where To Get Customers

TikTok and Instagram Reels (unboxing is the whole strategy); limited "drop" launches to your email/SMS list; wholesale to eco and gift boutiques via Faire; Etsy for gift buyers; college and local-pride markets; corporate/event merch orders for the novelty factor.

Pro Tips

- The unboxing is your ad — engineer a satisfying open (clean peel, visible seeds) and seed 30+ creators with free cans before launch.
- Run limited drops, not always-on inventory; scarcity drives the shares and lets you pre-sell before committing to a can run.
- Lean hard on the sustainability angle (reusable can + plantable seeds replaces throwaway plastic) — it converts eco buyers and justifies the premium.